

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 8
POST MAURYAN PERIOD
MODEL ANSWER FRAMEWORK

1. Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara art — 10 marks, 2019

What is demanded: Classify and illustrate the two streams of influence. Do not merely describe Gandhara art generally.

Introduction

Gandhara art developed in the Peshawar–Taxila–Swat region under Indo-Greek, Shaka-Parthian and Kushana rule. Buddhist in subject matter, it combined Central Asian cultural features with the classical artistic heritage transmitted through Greco-Bactria.

Body

Central Asian elements

- Kushana patronage connected Gandhara with Bactria and the Central Asian Silk Routes.
- Donors, guards and royal figures appear in Central Asian dress—long tunics or coats, trousers, belts, boots and caps.
- Moustached warriors, horsemen and martial figures reflect the region's Shaka-Kushana milieu.
- Frontal poses, rigid monumentality and sharply linear drapery display Scytho-Parthian or Iranian affinities.
- Foreign merchants and donors in Buddhist reliefs demonstrate Gandhara's multi-ethnic character.

Greco-Bactrian elements

- Naturalistic anatomy, proportion, muscular modelling and three-dimensional treatment of the human body.
- Wavy hair, youthful idealized faces and graceful postures derived from the Hellenistic classical tradition.
- Deeply carved folds resembling classical Mediterranean drapery.
- Corinthian capitals, acanthus leaves, vine scrolls, garland bearers and winged figures.
- Greek mythological forms were reinterpreted: **Heracles became Vajrapani**, while Atlas, Tritons and Erotes appeared as decorative figures.
- Continuous narrative reliefs and architectural framing reveal Hellenistic compositional methods.

Conclusion

Thus, Gandhara was not a passive imitation of foreign art. Central Asian rulers supplied its patronage and contemporary social types, Greco-Bactrian classicism supplied much of its form, while Indian Buddhism transformed both into a distinctive sacred idiom.

2. “Gandhara’s sculpture owed as much to the Romans as the Greeks.” Explain — 200 words, 2014

What is demanded: Demonstrate both Greek and Roman contributions, distinguish them where possible, and finally qualify the statement.

Introduction

Located at the meeting point of India, Bactria, Central Asia and western trade routes, Gandhara inherited Greek artistic traditions from the Indo-Greeks and encountered Roman forms through long-distance commerce and the Romanized eastern Mediterranean. Its classicism was consequently Greco-Roman rather than exclusively Greek.

Body

Greek contribution

- Idealized human proportions, anatomical naturalism and balanced postures.
- Wavy hair and youthful, Apollo-like facial types.
- Heracles as Vajrapani and the use of Atlas and other mythological figures.
- Corinthian pillars, acanthus decoration and Hellenistic narrative composition.

Roman contribution

- The Buddha’s heavy robe covering both shoulders, with deep folds, resembles the Roman toga.
- Greater frontal monumentality and individualised facial modelling recall Roman imperial portraiture; an early Gandharan bronze Buddha has even been compared with Neronian portrait types.
- Putti, garland bearers, wreaths, vine scrolls, Tritons and other marine figures were familiar in Roman decorative art.
- Crowded narrative panels and architectural frames resemble Roman reliefs and sarcophagi.
- Commercial links with the Roman world facilitated the circulation of objects, motifs and artistic conventions.

Conclusion

The statement is substantially valid, although Greek and Roman elements cannot always be separated because Roman art itself absorbed Hellenistic traditions. Nevertheless, Gandhara was not a Mediterranean copy: Buddhist subjects, mudras, *ushnisha*, *urna* and Indian religious purposes produced an original Indo-Greco-Roman synthesis.

3. Sangam literature and the social-economic conditions of South India — 2013

What is demanded: “Comment” requires a balanced evaluation:

1. Explain why Sangam literature cannot produce a connected political chronology.
2. Establish, with textual examples, why it remains vivid evidence for society and economy.
3. Mention corroboration by archaeology.

Introduction

The Sangam corpus—particularly the *Ettutokai* and *Pattuppattu*, together with the *Tolkappiyam*—reflects early historic Tamilakam around the beginning of the Common Era. As bardic poetry rather than historical chronicles, it provides fragmented political information but an exceptionally vivid picture of contemporary life.

Body

Limitations for political history

- The poems are classified chiefly into *akam*—love—and *puram*—war, generosity and public life—not chronological narratives.

- They were composed by numerous poets, transmitted orally and compiled later; consequently, their precise dates and textual layers remain uncertain.
- Panegyrics exaggerate the victories and generosity of patrons.
- References to Chera, Chola, Pandya and Velir chiefs are scattered, making dynastic succession and synchronisation difficult.
- Nevertheless, they provide political glimpses of warfare, capitals, tribute, cattle raids and chiefly redistribution.

Vivid social conditions

- The five *tinai* landscapes connect ecology with livelihood: *kurinji* with hunting, *mullai* with pastoralism, *marutam* with agriculture, *neital* with fishing and salt-making, and *palai* with raiding and travel.
- Poems describe love, marriage, kinship, hospitality, warfare, hero-stones and bard-patron relations.
- They mention rulers, Brahmanas, cultivators, pastoralists, merchants, artisans and labourers.
- Women poets such as Avvaiyar and female voices in *akam* poetry reveal aspects of women's experience, although patriarchy and widowhood were also present.
- Murugan, Mayon, Korravai and hero worship illuminate religious life.

Vivid economic conditions

- Wet-rice cultivation, irrigation, cattle-rearing, fishing and salt production.
- Textile manufacture, bead-making, metalwork and other specialised crafts.
- Ports such as Puhar, Muchiri and Korkai; exports included pepper, pearls, ivory and textiles.
- Yavana merchants, imported wine and gold indicate overseas commerce.
- *Pattinappalai* describes Puhar's harbour and customs activity; *Maduraikkanchi* portrays Madurai's busy markets.
- Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions, Roman coins, amphorae and port archaeology corroborate this commercial picture.
- The corpus is conventionally placed in early historic Tamilakam, though its dating remains debated,

Conclusion

Sangam literature cannot independently reconstruct a continuous dynastic history. However, when critically read and corroborated with archaeology, it constitutes the richest indigenous window into the ecology, occupations, inequalities, urbanisation and overseas trade of early Tamilakam.

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